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NEWSPAPER

18th December, 2017

ITEM WISE EDITORIALS

51st WEEK



NEPAL ... STABLE GOVERNMENT

UPSC CSE – GS II

GS II ... INDIA AND ITS NEIGHBORHOOD- RELATIONS.



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NEWSPAPER EDITORIALS

... DISCUSSION

18th DECEMBER, 2017

5

High road to democratic stability

With civic watch-dogging, Nepal, with its new Constitution, can turn history on its head



KANAK MANI DIXIT

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Constitutional confidence

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tional promulgation too has been overcome through sheer national public will. The citizenry feels empowered for having participated in each key episode of the last decade, including the People's Movement of 2006, blocking attempts at communal arson, and overcoming the five-month blockade of 2015-16.

The new Constitution marks an innovation in the South Asian landscape, with devolution of fiscal, legislative, executive and other powers not to two but three tier 'sarkars'.

Besides the national Parliament, the Constitution has empowered representative government in the seven provinces, 17 cities, 236 towns and 460 village municipalities. Emerging from a history of Kathmandu-centricism and two decades without elected local government, today an entire superstructure of representation is in place. Says the constitutionalist Nilamber Acharya: "A system of democratic filtering is in place, and there is excitement among the people to experiment with this new system."

Deuba's debacle

While the caretaker Prime Minister, Sher Bahadur Deuba, deserves all credit for guiding society through the maze of elections, he did run a lacklustre campaign and will not be thanked for the debilitation of the country's premier democratic party. While NC voters remained loyal, the Maoist swing vote and the romantic call of 'Left unity' made all the difference.

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The new Prime Minister's biggest success will be to 'neutralise' the Maoist party – through power-sharing or unification – and Mr. Dahal may be agreeable as his main worry of late has been to keep the cadre placated. In his previous stint as Prime Minister, Mr. Oli had almost brought the transitional justice process to a successful closure, including accountability for conflict-era excesses. The peace process will not be complete till this is done, and Mr. Oli's staying the course will en-

sure long-term peace and represent a victory for liberal democracy.

Beyond the Maoists, Mr. Oli will have to build a working relationship not only with the NC but also the plains-based parties with whom he has been combative. Democratic stability would, *ipso facto*, release long pending economic energy for which the new Prime Minister will have to fight rather than join the cronies capitalists who have entrapped the political economy during the decade of "political transition".

The economy has to start galloping, creating jobs for the young workforce, including the millions in of job migrants in West Asia, Malaysia and India likely to return due to pushes and pulls beyond Nepal's control. This requires movement on infrastructure projects, agro-forestry, tourism, service industries and irrigated agriculture in the Tarai plains.

The new Prime Minister will need to mend fences with New Delhi, energised by the strength of his electoral mandate. Based on the set of agreements signed in Beijing during his earlier stint at Singha Darbar, Mr. Oli is expected to accelerate connectivity to the north, utilising the Chinese railway network that has arrived on the Tibetan plateau.

Kathmandu does not yet fully understand Beijing's supercharged geopolitical agenda, but a confident Mr. Oli can be expected to seek a respectful rather than obsequious relationship. As the commentator Jaiendra Jeevan wrote last week, "We don't want another 'India' across the northern border."

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is bound to be bumpy, not least because the Constitution – written by politicians rather than jurists and constitutionalists – is so 'magnanimous' that it will be a challenge to implement. Hundreds of laws need drafting, the grey areas in the inter-relationships between the three levels of government have to be clarified.

The concurrent list detailing the rights and responsibilities of not two but three tiers makes Nepal's experiment unique. Already, one can sense reluctance among the topmost leadership and bureaucracy to devolve power to local government as mandated by the Constitution. The newly instituted Constitutional Bench of the Supreme Court will need to gear up to tackle the deluge.

There are enough triggers out there for social discontent to erupt. The profligacy of the last decade of "consensus governance" has emptied the national coffers even as expenditure is set to rise to meet the needs of local and provincial administration. The post-earthquake reconstruction of households, infrastructure and heritage structures has yet to gather steam.

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Kanak Mani Dixit, a writer and journalist based in Kathmandu, is founding editor of the magazine, 'Himal Southasian'

THE HINDU
INDIA'S NATIONAL NEWSPAPER SINCE 1878

Date :18th December, 2017

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BETTY HANCOCK/SHUTTERSTOCK

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IMPORTANT QUESTION

ESSAY/ MAINS / GD / INTERVIEWS

Nepal is heading for stable Government formation and examine various challenges for the new Nepal Government.

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NEPAL ELECTION RESULTS

- CPN (UML) ... 80 seats
- CPN (MC) ... 36 seats
- Nepali Congress ... 23 seats
- Rastriya Janata Party ... 11 seats
- Federal Socialist Forum ... 10 seats.

The tradition of the Nepali Congress setting the political agenda has been lost and Nepali's are heading for stable Government.

WHAT DOES THE ELECTIONS INDICATES?

- 1** Nepal is heading for Stable Government.
- 2** The elected representatives in all the three tiers indicate that the constitution is acceptable for all the stake holders.
- 3** Along with the Central Government, the constitution empowered Governments in seven Provinces and in local bodies will be in place.
- 4** Khadga Prasad Sharma Oli became the paramount leader. Under the new rules, no confidence motion cannot be brought for two years. Hence we can expect Stable Government.
- 5** The Economy is to be kick started to create jobs for the young work force.
- 6** Now the network connectivity to China will be accelerated, utilising the Chinese railway network, that has arrived in the Tibetan Plateau.
- 7** Now Khadga Prasad Sharma Oli has to establish relations with New Delhi.
- 8** Mr.Oli has to bring International respectability which was lost due to autocracy, conflict and transition.

WHAT DOES THE ELECTIONS INDICATES?

- 9** The grey areas in the constitution in interrelationships between the three levels of Government is to be clarified.
- 10** The powers to the local Government as mandated by the constitution are to be devolved.
- 11** The post earthquake reconstruction of households, infrastructure and heritage structures is to be fast-tracked.
- 12** The sharp differences in the economic status of seven units must be corrected.



KHADGA PRASAD OLI
Nepal

Overall the tasks are quite challenging and one has to wait and see how Khadga Prasad Oli will lead by maintaining balance between India, China, that too when special relationship exists with India since 1950.

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